

DAMSELFLIES AND DRAGONFLIES

These insects in the order Odonata have a distinctive long body with a mobile head and large eyes, giving good all-round vision. The adults have two pairs of similarly sized wings and are fast-flying hunters; the nymphs capture prey under water using their specialized mouthparts. Dragonflies are robust with a rounded head, whereas damselflies are more slender with a broader head and widely separated eyes.



6–8 cm
2¼–3¼ in

TWIN-SPOTTED SPIKETAIL

Cordulegaster maculata
F: Cordulegasteridae

This dragonfly is found in the E. USA and S.E. Canada, where it favours clean streams in wooded habitats.



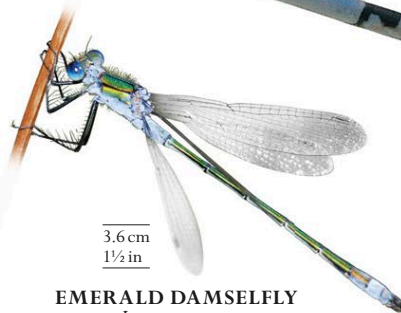
5.8–7.8 cm
2¼–3¼ in

PRINCE BASKETTAIL

Epitheca princeps
F: Corduliidae

A widespread N. American species, the prince baskettail can be seen patrolling ponds, lakes, creeks, and rivers from dawn until dusk.

wings held backwards when at rest



3.6 cm
1½ in

EMERALD DAMSELFLY

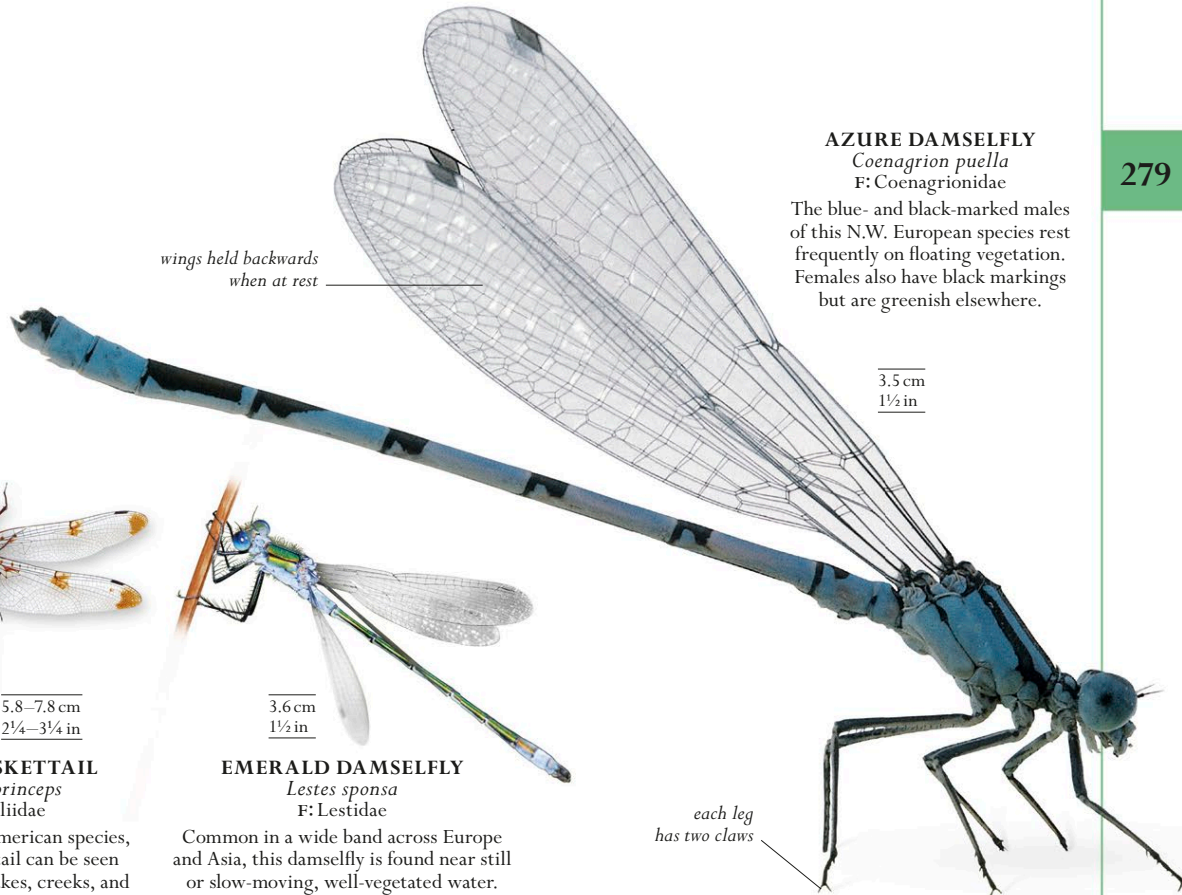
Lestes sponsa
F: Lestidae

Common in a wide band across Europe and Asia, this damselfly is found near still or slow-moving, well-vegetated water.

AZURE DAMSELFLY

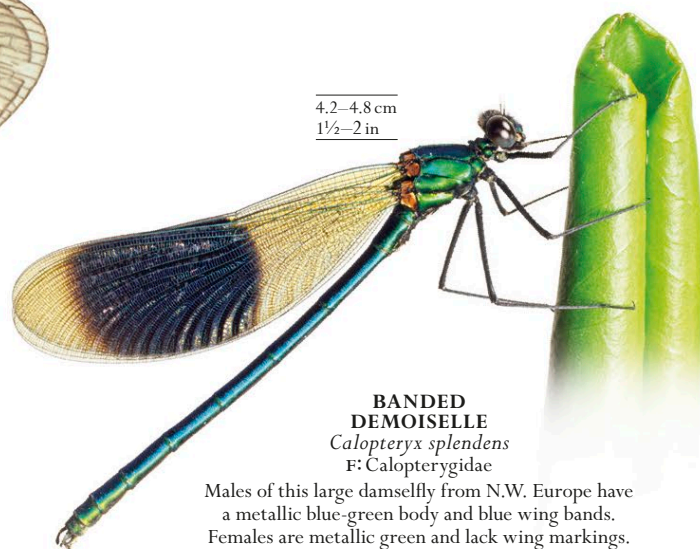
Coenagrion puella
F: Coenagrionidae

The blue- and black-marked males of this N.W. European species rest frequently on floating vegetation. Females also have black markings but are greenish elsewhere.



3.5 cm
1½ in

each leg has two claws

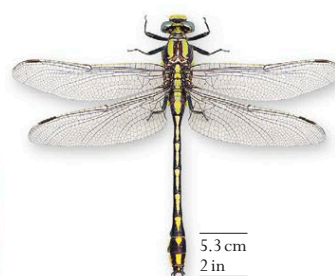


4.2–4.8 cm
1½–2 in

BANDED DEMOISELLE

Calopteryx splendens
F: Calopterygidae

Males of this large damselfly from N.W. Europe have a metallic blue-green body and blue wing bands. Females are metallic green and lack wing markings.

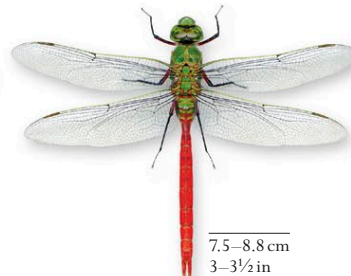


5.3 cm
2 in

PLAINS CLUBTAIL

Gomphus externus
F: Gomphidae

Flying on warm sunny days and breeding in slow-moving, muddy streams and rivers, this dragonfly is widespread in the USA.

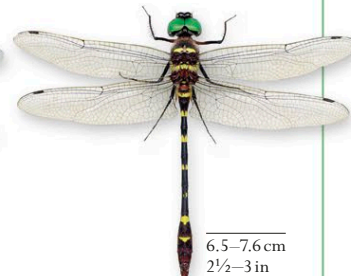


7.5–8.8 cm
3–3½ in

COMET DARTER

Anax longipes
F: Aeshnidae

Occurring from Brazil to Massachusetts, the comet darter can be found over lakes and large ponds and has a steady, regular flight pattern.

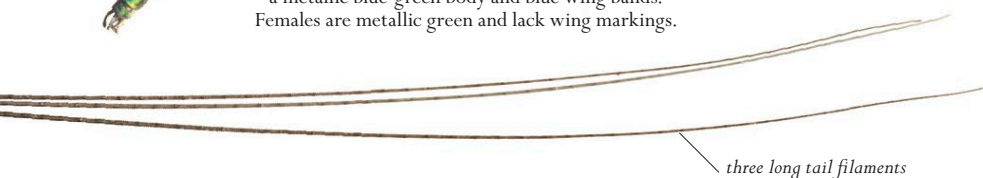


6.5–7.6 cm
2½–3 in

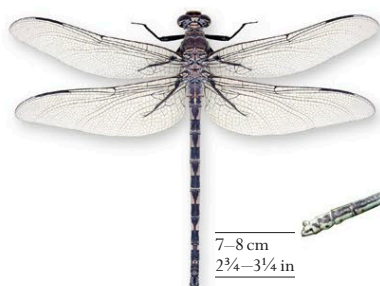
ILLINOIS RIVER CRUISER

Macromia illinoiensis
F: Macromiidae

This N. American species patrols gravelly or rocky streams and rivers, but can also be seen flying away from water along roads or tracks.



three long tail filaments

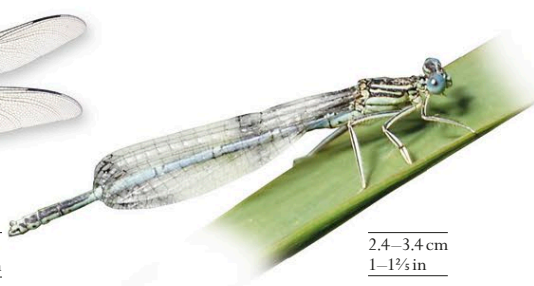


7–8 cm
2¾–3¼ in

GRAY PETALTAIL

Tachopteryx thoreyi
F: Petaluridae

A large dragonfly found in damp broad-leaved forests of the east coast of N. America, this species breeds in boggy areas and seeps.

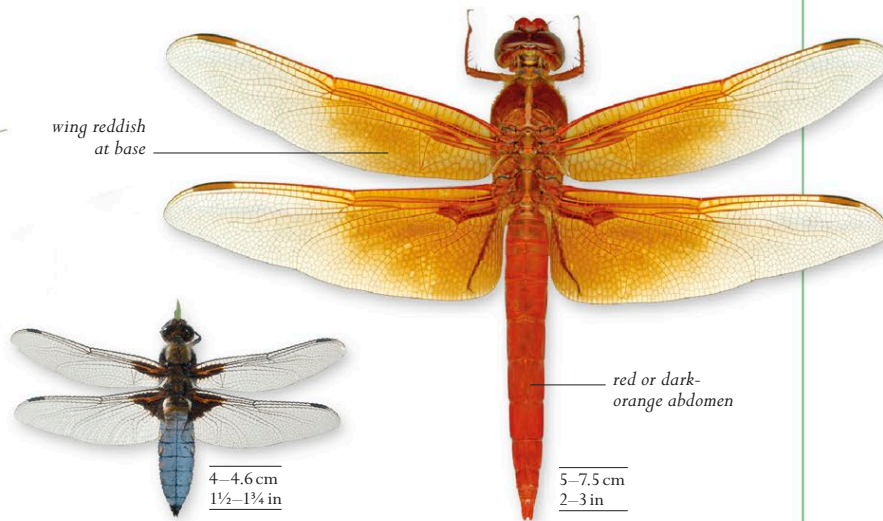


2.4–3.4 cm
1–1½ in

WHITE-LEGGED DAMSELFLY

Platycnemis pennipes
F: Platycnemididae

This damselfly from C. Europe breeds in slow-moving, weedy canals and rivers. The tibia of the hind leg is expanded and appears slightly feathery.



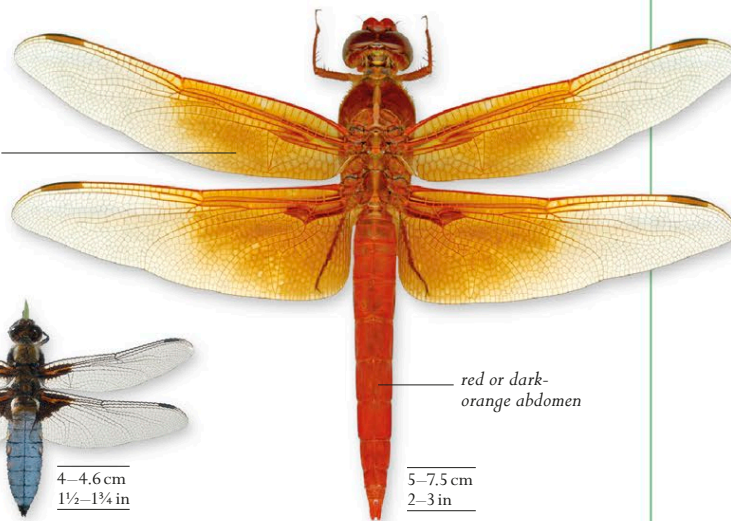
wing reddish at base

4–4.6 cm
1½–1¾ in

BROAD-BODIED CHASER

Libellula depressa
F: Libellulidae

This C. European and C. Asian species breeds in ditches and ponds. The abdomen of the male is blue above whereas that of the female is yellowish brown.



red or dark-orange abdomen

5–7.5 cm
2–3 in

FLAME SKIMMER

Libellula saturata
F: Libellulidae

Favouring warm ponds, streams, and even hot springs, this species is common in the S.W. USA.